

KEY



Major
shipwrecks
with known
coordinates

SS Islander (1901)

Its cargo of gold, which some estimate is worth up to \$700 million today, has never been found.

SS Sultana (1865)

This river steamer exploded in the Mississippi River with the loss of about 1,700 lives.

HMS Agamemnon (1809)

A former command of Admiral Nelson, she struck an uncharted group of rocks in a bay off Uruguay.

Scapa Flow (1919)

After World War I, the German navy sank 52 of its own ships here, rather than surrender them to Britain.

Méduse (1816)

When the *Méduse* sank, 147 crewmen built a life raft, but only 15 survived to be rescued.

Shipwrecks

The beds and shores of the world's seas, lakes, and rivers are littered with shipwrecks. Some are famous either for the huge loss of life they caused or the enormous value of their cargo.



Natural shipwrecks

Sailors battle constantly against the phenomenal forces of nature, and one of the most common causes of shipwrecks is bad weather. Storms and hurricanes batter ships and blow them off course, and fog, rain, or snow reduce visibility. Ice is another big risk. An iceberg can inflict fatal damage to a ship if it collides with one; while ice that builds up on the body of a ship can also cause it to become unstable and capsize.